MGMT2094 / STRATEGIC CREATIVITY & INNOVATION

Week 10: Agile Innovation and Lean Startup

How do organisations turn creative ideas into innovations when customer needs and circumstances keep changing?



Today’s Agenda

Week 10 · Agile Innovation & Lean Startup

01

Agile + Lean Startup

Concepts, Scrum and sprints

02

UniConnect Challenge

Three connected interactive cases

03

Share & Reflect

Team decisions and innovation takeaways

04

Assessment 2 Workshop

Work on your group video and strategy

Today’s progression: Understand Agile → Practise decisions → Apply to your project

What If the Plan Changes?

Imagine: Your team has spent two months developing a mobile app for university students. Just before launch, customer research reveals that students don't want several of its key features.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO?

A Continue with the original plan.

B Reconsider priorities based on feedback.

C Add the requested features while keeping everything originally planned.

DISCUSS • Choose one response and explain your reasoning.

What Is Agile?

Agile is an approach to managing complex work through collaboration, iterative development, feedback and adaptation.

THE AGILE CYCLE



Choose valuable work

Create usable outcomes

Gather feedback

Adjust the plan

Keep learning

Agile does not mean working without a plan. It means planning in shorter cycles and adapting as new information emerges.

Four Agile Values: From Principles to Practice

Foundational values (2001) and their application in organisational innovation (2016)

AGILE MANIFESTO · BECK ET AL. (2001)	ORGANISATIONAL PRACTICE · RIGBY ET AL. (2016)
Individuals and interactions over processes and tools	Empower cross-functional, self-managing teams to collaborate and make decisions.
Working software over comprehensive documentation	Deliver usable outcomes through short, iterative development cycles.
Customer collaboration over contract negotiation	Involve customers regularly to understand their needs and create value.
Responding to change over following a plan	Use feedback and continuous learning to adapt priorities and solutions.

Which value would be hardest to implement in a traditional organisation, and why?

Sources: Beck et al. (2001), Manifesto for Agile Software Development; Rigby, Sutherland & Takeuchi (2016), Embracing Agile, HBR.

How Do Agile Teams Actually Work?

From Agile principles to a practical framework for organising work

AGILE
Principles of collaboration, iterative delivery and adaptation

→

SCRUM
A framework that helps teams organise work into short, structured cycles called sprints

→

SPRINT
A fixed-length cycle of one month or less in which a team works towards a Sprint Goal and produces a usable increment

WHAT HAPPENS IN A SPRINT?

1 **Product Backlog**
Prioritised list of possible work

→

2 **Sprint Planning**
Set a Sprint Goal and select work

→

3 **Sprint**
Develop a usable increment

→

4 **Sprint Review**
Inspect results and adapt backlog

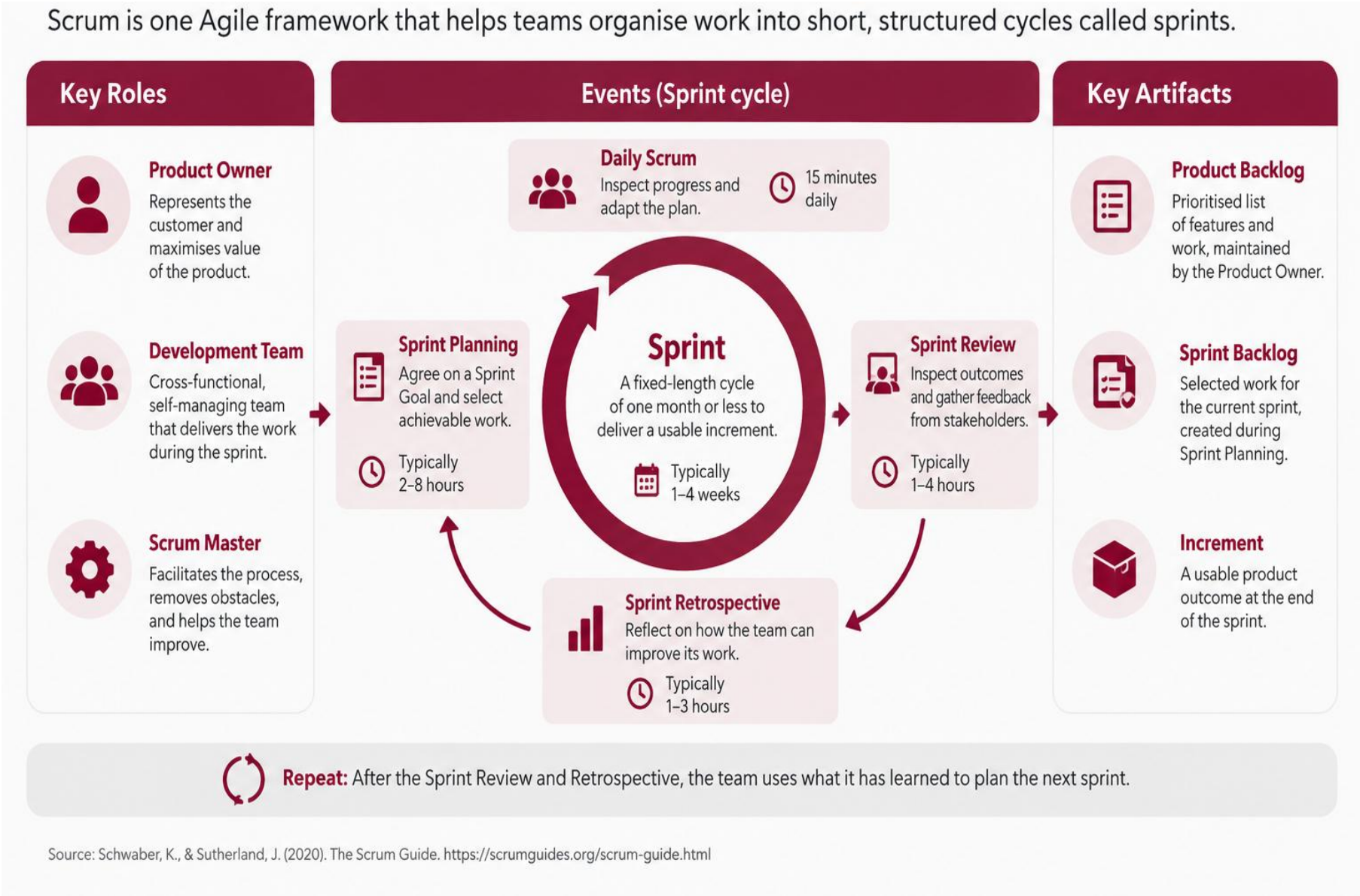
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5 **Retrospective**
Improve how the team works

↻ **Repeat: use feedback and learning to plan the next sprint.**

Scrum is one Agile framework; not all Agile teams use Scrum. Source: Schwaber & Sutherland (2020), The Scrum Guide.

SCRUM FRAMEWORK



Source: Schwaber, K., & Sutherland, J. (2020). The Scrum Guide. https://scrumguides.org/scrum-guide.html

Your Challenge: Become an Agile Innovation Team



UniConnect

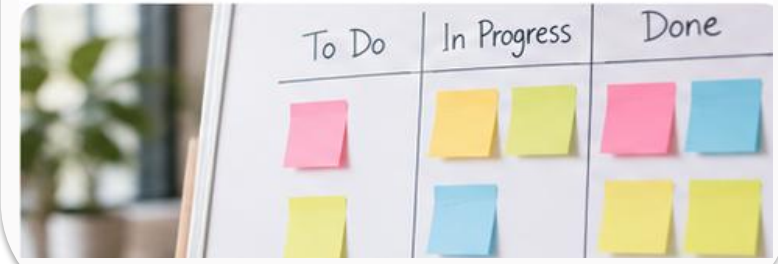
A university-backed startup developing a platform to help students connect with peers, find study partners and participate in campus activities.
Click to Start Your Group Challenge

- Connect with peers
- Find study partners
- Join campus activities

Round 1

Manage tasks

Prioritise the product backlog and plan your first Agile sprint.



→

Round 2

Manage change

Use customer feedback to revise priorities and plan your next experiment.



→

Round 3

Manage innovation

Identify organisational barriers and recommend how managers can enable Agile.



What Did We Learn About Managing Innovation?

Three levels of decision-making in the UniConnect challenge

01

MANAGING TASKS

Prioritise work based on value and capacity.

02

MANAGING CHANGE

Test assumptions and adapt based on evidence.

03

MANAGING BARRIERS

Remove organisational barriers and enable cross-functional collaboration.

DISCUSSION

Which was the hardest decision: prioritising, adapting or managing organisational barriers?

Agile + Lean Startup + Lean Strategy

These three approaches complement one another to help organisations innovate more effectively.

Agile

How do we organise teams to develop and improve innovations?



- Organise work into short, iterative cycles (sprints)
- Enable collaboration and quick adaptation
- Continuously improve the product

Lean Startup

How do we test whether our innovation creates value for customers?



- Test assumptions with real users
- Learn from feedback and adapt
- Develop solutions that create value for customers

Lean Strategy

How do we ensure experimentation remains aligned with strategic direction?



- Set direction, scope and guardrails for experimentation
- Prioritise the right opportunities
- Allocate resources effectively

Discussion

Can an organisation be Agile and still fail to innovate successfully?

Assessment 2 | Group Video Submission

DUE MON 19 OCT 2026 · 11:59 PM (WEEK 11)

WEIGHT 30%

How to submit

1. Upload your 6–7 minute group video to YouTube or another streaming platform.
2. One group member submits a Word document containing the video link.
3. Include all group names, student IDs, class details, tutor's name, references and a 100-word video descriptor.

Assessment criteria

CONTENT
Inform, persuade and recommend; relevant, high-quality research

STRUCTURE
Logical sequence and effective signposting

INTEREST
Audience awareness; engaging techniques and visuals

DELIVERY
Clear verbal and non-verbal communication

TIME & PACE
Within 6–7 minutes; appropriate pacing

TEAMWORK
Preparation, unity and equal contribution

Review the assessment rubric for detailed descriptors.